Scripps

Learning About Diabetes Medications

Your medication schedule may be different when hospitalized (or between home and hospital). You should check your home schedule with your doctor at discharge.

Pills

DRUG TYPE AND NAME	HOW IT WORKS	POSSIBLE SIDE EFFECTS	TALK WITH YOUR DOCTOR
GLUCOPHAGE (Metformin)	Keeps liver from releasing too much sugar.	Can cause diarrhea, stomach cramps and gas.	If you have lung, kidney, or liver problems, CHF or congestive heart failure or a weakened heart.
DIABETA (Glyburide) GLUCOTROL (Glipizide) AMARYL (Glimiperide)	Stimulates the pancreas to release more insulin.	Low blood sugar, nausea, vomiting and weight gain.	If you have liver or kidney problems or allergies to sulfa medications.
JANUVIA (Sitagliptin) ONGLYZA (Saxagliptin) TRADJENTA (Linagliptin)	Keeps the liver from releasing too much sugar and increases insulin during meals.	Headache, stomach cramps, diarrhea or runny nose.	If you have kidney or liver disease.
ACTOS (Pioglitazone) AVANDIA (Rosiglitazone)	Makes muscle cells more sensitive to insulin.	Low blood sugar, headache, swelling, weight gain or swollen ankles.	If you have heart or liver problems. May cause swelling of face or legs. May increase risk of chest pain or heart attack.
PRECOSE (Acarbose) GLYSET (Miglitol)	Slows the digestion of carbohydrates.	Stomach cramps and diarrhea.	If you have stomach or liver problems.
PRANDIN (Repaglinide) STARLIX (Nateglinide)	Raises the amount of insulin in the body.	Low blood sugar, weight gain or flu-like symptoms.	If you have kidney or liver problems. Avoid grapefruit and grapefruit juice.

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Insulin and Other Injectables

Insulin

DRUG TYPE AND NAME	HOW IT WORKS	STARTS WORKING	WORKS STRONGEST	ENDS	INSTRUCTIONS
APIDRA (Glulisine) HUMALOG (Lispro) NOVOLOG (Aspart)	Bolus Rapid-Acting	5-15 Minutes	1-2 Hours	4-6 Hours	Looks clear. Take with meals.
Regular	Bolus Short-Acting	30-60 Minutes	2-3 Hours	6-8 Hours	Looks clear. Take 30 minutes before meals.
NPH	Basal Intermediate-Acting	2-4 Hours	6-10 Hours	10-18 Hours	Looks Cloudy. Roll to mix. Take as ordered.
LANTUS (Glargine) LEVEMIR (Detemir)	Basal Long-Acting	1-2 Hours		Approximately 24 Hours	Looks clear. Take at same time every day. Do not mix with other insulins.
50/50 and 70/30	Combination Pre-Mix with Regular	30-60 Minutes	3-12 Hours	12-20 Hours	Looks cloudy. Roll to mix. Take as ordered.
75/25 and 70/30	Combination Pre-Mix with Rapid-Acting	30-60 Minutes	3-12 Hours	12-20 Hours	Looks cloudy. Roll to mix. Take as ordered.

Other Injectables

DRUG TYPE AND NAME	HOW IT WORKS	POSSIBLE SIDE EFFECTS
BYETTA/BYDUREON (Exenatide) VICTOZA (Liraglutide)	Helps increase insulin production.	Nausea, vomiting Decreased appetite Constipation
SYMLIN (Pramlintide)	Helps lower after-meal blood sugar levels. Used with insulin at mealtime.	Nausea, vomiting Decreased appetite